

Bengal under Afghan & Mughal Rule

Afghan rule in Bengal

- ▶ Afghan rule in Bengal primarily refers to the period from 1538 to 1576 CE. Afghan rule began in Bengal in 1538CE with the conquest of Bengal by Sher Khan or Sher Shah Suri. His dynastic rule is known as the Suri Empire.
- ▶ Another Afghan dynasty that ruled Bengal is Karrani Dynasty. Established by Taj Khan Karrani in 1563 ,this dynasty's rule continued till 1576. Doud Karrani was the last ruler of this dynasty who was killed and defeated by Mughal Governor Khan-e-Jahan in the battle of Rajmahal, thus bringing an end to Afghan rule in Bengal.
- ▶ Karrani Dynasty shifted the capital from Gouda to Tanda.

Bengal under Mughal Empire

- ▶ Bengal became a part of Mughal Empire under Emperor Akbar who conquered Bengal in 1556 after defeating Daud Khan Karrani, the last independent ruler.
- ▶ Bengal was declared a Subah (province) during Mughal period. The first Governor of Bengal appointed by Emperor Akbar was Munim Khan. Gouda was his capital. Emperor Jahangir appointed Islam Khan as Governor of Bengal. He shifted the capital to Dhaka in 1610 and renamed it Jahangirnagar after Emperor Jahangir. Dhaka flourished during the Mughal period, especially during the time of Governor Shah Suja and Shaista Khan. Many served as governor of Bengal.
- ▶ Despite Mughal victories, they initially faced fierce resistance from Barobhuiyans. Barobhuiyans were the local chiefs or zamindars, who put up strong resistance during Mughal emperor Akbar and Jahangir's reigns. They were not exactly twelve in number. They were zamindars and warlords who fought against Mughals to protect their own interest. They were unified and led by Isa Khan. Under him, the capital was Sonargaon.
- ▶ Bengal was a very prosperous and wealthy part of the Mughal Empire. Its agriculture and textile were very famous. There was assimilation of Hindu and Muslim culture.
- ▶ Viceroy Ibrahim Khan gave permission to the Portuguese, French and British traders to do business in Bengal.

The Nawabs of Bengal

- ▶ The Nawabs of Bengal were a line of hereditary rulers who governed Bengal Subah. In the 18th century, They became increasingly independent from Mughal Emperor and essentially ruled three regions - Bengal, Bihar and Orissa as their own kingdom. Notable among them are Murshid Kuli Khan, Alibardi Khan, Siraj ud Daulah.
- ▶ Murshidkuli Khan shifted the capital to Murshidabad. The British East India Company eventually gained control after battle of Palashi in 1757.
- ▶ In 1772 Bengal came under direct British rule.

Battle of Plassey

The Battle of Plassey in 1757 was a key event in Indian history. It marked a major turning point for the British East India Company, changing it from a trading company into a major political power in India.

Background to the Battle

The [Mughal Empire](#), which once controlled most of India, was declining in the 1700s. Bengal, a rich province, was ruled by the nawabs of Bengal.

The [British East India Company](#), which had its own army, came to India in the 1600s for trade. By the mid-1700s, they had a strong military presence. They also competed with the French East India Company for influence.

In 1756, Sirāj al-Dawlah became the nawab of Bengal and favored the French. He captured Calcutta and Fort William and confined British prisoners in a small dungeon, where many died. This event, known as the Black Hole of Calcutta, was used by the British to justify their revenge. Robert Clive was sent to retake Calcutta.

Background and causes

- ▶ **Misuse of Trade Privileges:** The EIC officials misused duty-free trade permits (dastaks) for personal profit, causing significant revenue loss to the Bengal treasury.
- ▶ **Unauthorized Fortification:** Despite the Nawab's objections, the British reinforced their factories and forts, specifically in Calcutta (Fort William), which was perceived as a direct challenge to the Nawab's sovereignty.
- ▶ **Asylum to Political Fugitives:** The British provided protection to Krishna Das, son of Raj Ballabh, a political enemy of the Nawab who fled with vast treasures.
- ▶ **The Black Hole Tragedy (1756):** The imprisonment of British soldiers in a small, suffocating room after Siraj-ud-Daulah captured Calcutta served as a major catalyst for retaliation.
- ▶ **Conspiracy and Intrigue:** Internal dissatisfaction within the Nawab's court led British officials, led by Robert Clive, to conspire with Mir Jafar (the army chief), Rai Durlabh, and others, promising to make Mir Jafar the new Nawab.
- ▶ **French Influence:** The growing alliance between the French and Siraj-ud-Daulah caused apprehension among the British, prompt

Battle and Impact

- ▶ The Battle of Plassey was fought on 23 June 1757. Clive advanced on the nawab's capital, Murshidabad, and faced the nawab's army of 50,000 men, including 16,000 cavalry and a French-officered force of some 50 field guns. Clive's army was much smaller, consisting of only 3,000 men, which included 2,100 Indian soldiers (sepoys) and about 800 Europeans, with only 10 field guns. But Clive had an ace up his sleeve. The vastly rich Jagat Seth banking family of Bengal, which had previously supported the nawabs, feared the stoppage of the lucrative European trade in the event of the nawab's victory, and hence they threw in their lot with the British. Together, Clive and the Jagat Seths succeeded in turning Mīr Ja'far, one of the nawab's commanders, to their side with the promise of making him the next Nawab
- ▶ It lasted for about eight hours and the nawab was defeated by the company because of the treachery of his leading general Mir Zafar. Plassey's political consequences were far-reaching and devastating and hence, though a mere skirmish, it has been magnified into a battle.
- ▶ It laid the foundation of the British rule in Bengal. For the English East India Company, Bengal was the springboard from which the British expanded their territorial domain and subsequently built up the empire which gradually engulfed most parts of India and ultimately many parts of Asia as well.
- ▶ Mir Jafar became the Nawab of Bengal and Bengal became a British puppet state following the defeat.

Clive meeting Mir Jafar after the Battle of Plassey, oil on canvas (Francis Hayman, c. 1762)



Battle of Buxar: Causes

- ▶ Key causes included:
 - ▶ **Misuse of Trade Privileges:** Company officials misused dastaks (free passes) for personal gain, causing major revenue losses to the Bengal treasury.
 - ▶ **Abolition of Internal Duties:** To create a level playing field for local merchants and curtail British monopoly, Mir Qasim abolished all inland duties, which enraged the British.
 - ▶ **Asserting Independence:** Mir Qasim moved his capital from Murshidabad to Munger, built a modern army with European training, and tried to act independently, violating the "puppet" status expected by the Company.
 - ▶ **Alliance Formation:** After being defeated in earlier skirmishes in 1763, Mir Qasim fled and formed an alliance with Shuja-ud-Daula (Nawab of Awadh) and Shah Alam II (Mughal Emperor) to drive the British out of Bengal.

Battle and its impact

- ▶ The Battle of Buxar was fought between 22 and 23 October 1764, between the forces of the British East India Company, under the command of Major Hector Munro, against the combined armies of Balwant Singh, Maharaja of the Benaras State; Mir Qasim, the Nawab of Bengal; Nawab wazir, the Nawab of Awadh; and Shah Alam II, the Emperor of the Mughal Empire.
- ▶ The Battle of Buxar had far-reaching consequences that reshaped the political landscape of colonial India. Its aftermath witnessed significant shifts in power dynamics and set the stage for British dominance in the Bengal region.
- ▶ Following their victory over the combined forces of the Nawab of Bengal, the Nawab of Awadh, and the Mughal Emperor—the three main scions—the British East India Company emerged as the preeminent power in Bengal. The battle was the beginning of the end for the Mughal Empire's political control, as the Company continued to consolidate its influence over vast territories.

Mir Quasim, Nawab of Bengal



ARRIVAL OF THE NAWAB BEFORE CLIVE'S POSITION.
Engraved by R. Colvin Woodville.